

Isha Bhallamudi

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

2024-25 Postdoctoral Fellow, Digital Civil Society Lab & Dept. of Communication, Stanford University
Advisor: Angèle Christin

EDUCATION

- 2024** Ph.D. Sociology. University of California Irvine.
Committee: Swethaa Ballakrishnen (co-chair), Rachel Goldberg (co-chair), Francesca Polletta, Tom Boellstorff, Paul Dourish
Dissertation Title: “It’s Always Been Women’s Work: Tracing Gender, Technology, and Work in India Through an Account of AI-Mediated Beauty Work”
- 2021** M.A. Demographic and Social Analysis. University of California Irvine.
- 2017** Integrated M.A. Development Studies. Indian Institute of Technology Madras.
Dissertation title: “Exploring Adolescent Health in Tamil Nadu through the National Adolescent Health Program: Where Do Implementation Status and Access to Healthcare Stand?”

AREAS OF SPECIALIZATION

Technology, Work, Organizations, Inequality, Civil Society, Social Wellbeing, Development, Global South

SKILLS

- **Methods:** Interviews, ethnography, surveys, focus group discussions, literature reviews, participatory approaches, community-based research, adolescent-centered approaches.
- **Analysis:** Survey data analysis (proficient), qualitative analysis (proficient), regression analysis (proficient), statistical inference & hypothesis testing (basic), demographic analysis (basic), networks analysis (basic), policy analysis (basic) & content analysis (basic).
- **Software:** STATA, R, Dedoose, Atlas.ti, Excel, LaTeX, Zotero.
- **Languages:** English (native), Hindi (native), Telugu (proficient), Tamil (basic).

PEER-REVIEWED JOURNAL PUBLICATIONS

1. Forthcoming. **Bhallamudi, I.** “Ghosts in the Machine: How Caste Patriarchy Shapes Management Practices in Beauty Platforms”. In Cameron, L. (ed), ‘Thinking with and Beyond Labor and Tech: An Empirical Investigation of How the Ghost Variables of Race, Caste, Gender, Citizenship, and Class Shape Gig Work’, *Journal of Management Inquiry*.
2. Forthcoming. Turney, K., Schmidt, S., Torres, A., **Bhallamudi, I.** and Liu, A.G. “One More Thing on My Mental List”: Cognitive Labor During Family Member Incarceration”. *Social Forces*.
3. [2023. Kitojo, W., Kalisa, M., Bray, R. & Bhallamudi, I. “Applying ‘Merging of Knowledge’ in Tanzania: What Can we Learn About Interrupting Patterned Relationships to Reveal New Dimensions of Poverty?”. *Action Research*, 22\(1\), pp. 15-31.](#)
4. [2022. **Bhallamudi, I.** ‘Daughters, Devices and Doorkeepers: How Gender and Class Shape Inequalities in Adolescents’ Access to Technology in Mumbai, India’. *Information, Communication and Society*, 25\(6\), pp. 851-867.](#)

5. [2019. Bhallamudi, I. & Lingam, L. “Swaying between saving the Environment and Mitigating Women’s Domestic Drudgery: India’s Efforts at Addressing Clean Cooking Fuels”. *Gender, Technology and Development*, 23\(1\), pp. 36-54.](#)

BOOK CHAPTERS, CONFERENCE PUBLICATIONS, AND REPORTS

*: equal authorship

1. Forthcoming, Ballakrishnen, S. & **Bhallamudi, I.** “Different Gigs: Aspiration and Mobility Variations in Indian Gig Work” in Dent, M. et al (eds). *2nd Handbook of Professions and Professionalism*. Routledge.
2. Forthcoming. Alladi, H. and ***Bhallamudi, I.** “Dreaming of Home: Female Friendships and Collaborative Sense-Making of the Home and Self” in Phadke, S., Kanagasabai, N., & Mohanty, H. (eds). *Friendships in South Asia*. Routledge.
3. [2026. Černušáková, B. and Bhallamudi, I. “Technology and Labour” in Gillan, K. & May, V \(eds\). *Interrogating Global Social Challenges*. Bristol University Press.](#)
4. [2024. Lingam, L. & Bhallamudi, I. ““Good Girls” and “Bad Boys”: Smartphones and the Social Reproduction of Gender” in Lingam, L. and Mkhwanazi, N. \(eds\). *Digital Technologies and Gendered Realities*. Routledge.](#)
5. 2024. **Bhallamudi, I.**, Hapke, H., Ponciano, L., Wagner-Huang, W., & Walker, B. “Individual-level and Institutional-level Bias in Grant Proposal Review”. Report for the California Alliance of Hispanic-Serving Social Science Institutions.
6. [2023. *Bhallamudi, I & Malik, L. “Influence as Method and Method as Influence: Collaborative Platform Work in Mumbai and Delhi”. In *Proceedings of the Social Media & Society in India Conference*, University of Michigan.](#)
7. [2023. Bhallamudi, I. “Gig Workers and HCXAI in the Global South: An Evaluative Typology”. In *Proceedings of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human-Centered Explainable AI \(CHI '23\)*, Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA.](#)
8. [2019. Bhaskaran, J. & Bhallamudi, I. “Good Secretaries, Bad Truck Drivers? Occupational Gender Stereotypes in Sentiment Analysis”. In *Proceedings of the First Workshop on Gender Bias in Natural Language Processing*, Association for Computational Linguistics, Florence, Italy.](#)
9. [2019. Lingam, L., Bhallamudi, I & Rao, N. “Gender Mainstreaming Across Agriculture, Urban Planning and Governance: Lessons for India”. UN Women: Mumbai.](#)
10. [2018. Lingam, L., Bhallamudi, I & Rao, N. “Adolescent Sub-cultures and Smartphones: Exploring Implications for Gender, Sexuality and Rights”. UNICEF: Mumbai.](#)
11. 2018. Rao, N. and **Bhallamudi, I.** “[Collaborative Knowledge Creation: Interrogating Processes and Patterns](#)”. Workshop Report for the Tata Institute of Social Sciences and Committee of Resource Organizations (CORO).
12. 2015. Bray, R., & **Bhallamudi, I.** (with Ugarte, A). “Doing Participative Research: What is Needed to Make it Work?”. 3 part Working Paper Series presented at the Collaborative Research Design Workshop between ATD Fourth World and the University of Oxford.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER PREPARATION

1. **Bhallamudi, I.** “Cyclical Re-Entries”: Women’s Work Pathways in the Platform Economy”.
2. **Bhallamudi, I.** “Inside the Beauty Platform Organization: New Forms of Gendered Algorithmic Management”.

3. **Bhallamudi, I.** & Raval, N. “Adaptive Peer Infrastructures: How Indian Immigrant Tech Workers Navigate Layoffs in Silicon Valley”.
4. **Bhallamudi, I.** “A Feminist, Bottom-up Platform Evaluation Framework”. Report and resource kit being developed in consultation with women gig workers and women-led unions.
5. Turney, K., Schmidt, S., **Bhallamudi, I.**, Torres, A. and Liu, A.G. “Carceral Brokering: How Families Manage the Strains of Incarceration”.

PUBLIC MEDIA

1. 2026. “[Gender Dimensions of Platform Work: What Does it Mean for Unionizing?](#)” (with Eesha Kunduri and Anushree Gupta). *Platypus*, the Committee for the Anthropology of Science, Technology, and Computing blog.
2. 2026. “[No Shade in the Gig Economy: A Call for Gender-Equitable Heat Protections](#)”. *HeatWatch*.
3. 2026. “[Big Tech Wants You to Get Digisexual](#)”. *The Swaddle*.
4. 2025. “[Series Introduction: The Politics of Writing About Platform Workers’ Organizing](#)”. (with Anushree Gupta). *Platypus*, the Committee for the Anthropology of Science, Technology, and Computing blog.
5. 2024. “[Since When?](#)”. *Femwork Podcast*. (Hosted by Shruti Singhania).
6. 2021. “[Gender Parity in India: What a Case of ‘Accidental Feminism’ Can Offer](#)”. *Oxford Human Rights Hub Blog*.
7. 2021. “[Girls, Gadgets, and Gatekeepers: What is Ethical Feminist Fieldwork When Working with Children?](#)”. *Platypus*, the Committee for the Anthropology of Science, Technology, and Computing blog.
8. 2020. “[Bespoke but not Woke](#)”: A commentary on the show Indian Matchmaking. *Economic and Political Weekly*. Vol 55, Issue 31.
9. 2020. “[Outrage and Othering: ‘Bois Locker Room’](#)”: A commentary on online gender-based violence in India. *Economic and Political Weekly*. Vol 55. Issue 20.
10. 2020. “[Rowdy Without a Cause?](#)”: A commentary on misogyny in South Indian films. *Economic and Political Weekly*. Vol. 55. Issue 6.
11. 2018. “[Positive Approaches to Adolescents and Sexuality Education: A Case for Expanding Regional Vocabularies](#)”. Family Planning Association of India (blog post).
12. 2016. “[Gender-Based Harassment: a Reality on Campus?](#)” The Fifth Estate, IIT Madras. (2-part article based on a survey of 800 students that I designed, conducted & analysed).
13. 2016. “Inside Healthcare Policy”. Immerse: IIT Madras Science Magazine.
14. 2014. “Vials on Dial”. Immerse: IIT Madras Science Magazine.

RESEARCH FEATURED IN MEDIA

- [What Will Protect People from Hate Crimes in the Metaverse?](#), The Swaddle, Jan 2022
- [TISS-UNICEF Study on Smartphone Use by Adolescents](#), DNA India, Jun 2018
- [Fathima Lateef: Death on the Campus](#), Open Magazine, Nov 2018

WORK EXPERIENCE

- **UX Research Intern, Fitbit, Google (San Francisco, CA)** 06/22 – 09/22
 Researched 1) cognitive and emotional trust drivers and 2) unmet health needs of Black+ user communities using literature reviews and in-depth interviews, to help drive long-term trust-building efforts at Fitbit.
- **Graduate Student Researcher, Jail & Family Life Project, UC Irvine** 06/20 – 03/22

PI: Kristin Turney

Carried out collaborative qualitative coding and analysis of 625 interviews with incarcerated men and their family members, to study how families distribute and manage the burdens and cognitive labor associated with incarceration.

- **Graduate Student Researcher, California Alliance for Hispanic-serving Social Science**

Advancement, UC Irvine

06/20 – 08/24

PI (UCI): Holly Hapke

Assisted in conducting faculty development webinars, and conducted a literature review and interview project, to examine individual and institutional-level bias in the grant review process.

- **Graduate Student Researcher, Diversity and Networking in Law School: Are Students from Diverse Backgrounds Disadvantaged?, UC Irvine** 06/20 – 03/22

PI (UCI): Swethaa Ballakrishnen

Carried out regression analysis of law student survey data across 3 universities, to examine how students' social networks and diversity traits shape their belongingness in law school.

- **Field Research Assistant, Treasure Hunt: Social Learning in the Field, National Bureau of Economic Research.** 09/15 – 05/16

PI: Markus Mobius (University of Michigan), Adam Szeidl (CEU)

Adapted project design and implementation to IIT Madras, monitored project website and handled data collection, and designed and implemented publicity strategies to reach target participation goals.

- **Research Assistant, Tata Institute of Social Sciences, Mumbai** 06/17 – 08/18

PI: Lakshmi Lingam

Carried out 3 research and consultancy projects (for UN Women, UNICEF and the Telangana State Police Academy), using pilot studies, primary research, organizational strategy and policy analyses.

- **Research Intern, Dept. of Social Policy and Intervention, University of Oxford** 06/15 – 07/15

PI: Robert Walker

Helped adapt a novel participatory methodology and develop the research design for an [international 6-country study of multidimensional poverty](#), later presented at the UN and OECD in 2020.

HONORS, PRIZES AND GRANTS

- 2023. **Graduate Dean's Dissertation Fellowship**, UC Irvine.
- 2023. **Graduate Student Grant**, Center for Asian Studies, UC Irvine.
- 2023. **Honorable Mention**, Outstanding Graduate Research Award, Dept. Sociology, UC Irvine.
- 2022. **Outstanding Graduate Research Award**, Dept. of Sociology, UC Irvine.
- 2022. **Small Grant**, Center for Organizational Research, UC Irvine.
- 2022. **Noyce Fellowship in AI, Law and Society**, UC Irvine (with Swethaa Ballakrishnen).
- 2022. **Finalist**, SSRC International Dissertation Research Fellowship.
- 2022. **Summer Research Fellowship**, Dept. of Sociology, UC Irvine.
- 2021. **Graduate Fellow**, Center for Networks and Relational Analysis, UC Irvine.
- 2021. **Conference Grant**, Associated Graduate Students, UC Irvine.
- 2019-2023. **Summer Research Grant**, Dept. of Sociology, UC Irvine.
- 2019. **Summer Research Fellowship**, Dept. of Sociology, UC Irvine.
- 2018. **Graduate Dean's Recruitment Fellowship**, UC Irvine.

- 2015. **Research Travel Grant**, IIT Madras, India.
- 2015 & 2014. **Institute Merit Prize** for academic excellence. IIT Madras, India.
- 2012. **DST-INSPIRE scholarship**, awarded to top 1% of STEM high school students in India. Ministry of Science & Technology, Government of India.

SELECTED CONFERENCES AND TALKS

1. Forthcoming. "New Platforms, Old Pathways: What Does AI-Mediated Platform Work Mean for the Future of Women's Work in India?". Invited research talk at the School of Information Studies, **UCLA**.
2. 2025. "Gig Work and Algorithmic Decisions: What Happens When Things Go Wrong?". Guest lecture for **Politics of Algorithms course, Stanford University**.
3. 2025. "Rethinking AI Explainability". Guest lecture for **Ethics and Activism in Tech and Design, UC Santa Cruz**.
4. 2025. "Campaigning Around IPOs". Workshop conducted at **Gig Workers United: Reimagining Global Justice in the Era of AI and Emerging Platform Capitalism conference, Geneva**. (The first ever convening of global gig unions, held alongside the International Labor Convention).
5. 2025. "Navigating the Algorithmic Maze: How Women Access Beauty Platform Work", **ICA Annual Conference, Denver**.
6. 2025. "Using or being useful? Reflections on academic engagement with organizing and worldbuilding in the women's gig organizing sector in Mumbai". '**Unsettling Global Media and Communication Studies**' Symposium, CARGC, UPenn.
7. 2023. "The Women Who Hold Up Platforms – Gender, Precarity and Resistance in Gig Work in Mumbai, India". **Pre-Conference Workshop on Platform Economies, ASA**.
8. 2023. "Organizing Against Precarity: Learning from Women Gig Workers in India", **ASA Annual Conference**.
9. 2023. "How Women Platform Workers Fight Back – Gendered Modes of Resistance and Strategization Among Beauty Gig Workers in Mumbai, India", **AoIR Annual Meeting**.
10. 2023. "What Gig Work Can Tell Us About Women's Employment Futures: A Study of Women Platform Workers in Mumbai", **Annual Conference on South Asia, University of Wisconsin-Madison**.
11. 2023. "It's Always Been Women's Work": The Gender Dynamics of App-Based Work in Mumbai". Research Talk, Department of Communication, **University of Hyderabad**.
12. 2023. "Women, Work and Technology in India: Current Trends and Future Opportunities". Invited talk for Women's Day, English Department, **Payyanur College**.
13. 2023. "Academic Paper Publishing". Workshop conducted at the Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, **IIT Madras**.
14. 2022. **Bhallamudi, I.**, Ballakrishnen, S., Whitworth, W., Boutcher, S., Silver, C., & Paik, A. "Diverse Belongings: How Social Networks Change the Ways in Which We Belong in Law School". **Law and Society Association Annual Conference**.
15. 2022. Turney, K., Schmidt, S., **Bhallamudi, I.**, Torres, A. and Liu, A.G. "Burdens of Brokering: How Families Manage the Burden of Incarceration". **ASA Annual Meeting**.
16. 2022. Dinsmore, B., Jonas, A., Rafalow, M., Outland, S., Puckett, C., Miner, M. & **Bhallamudi, I.** "“Cameras On”: How Schools Reify Social Inequality through Decisions about Online Visibility”., **ASA Annual Meeting | Sociology of Education Annual Meeting**.

17. 2022. “Daughters, Devices and Doorkeeping: How Gender and Class Shape Adolescent Mobile Phone Access in Mumbai”. Guest Lecture for the Feminist Economic & Policy Initiative at **OP Jindal Global University**.
18. 2021. “Ethical Dilemmas During Fieldwork with Adolescents in India: Complicating and Questioning Ideas of Feminist Fieldwork in the Global South”, **4S Annual Meeting | Anthropology in Transit Conference**, UC Irvine.
19. 2021. “Girls, Gadgets and Gatekeepers: Gendered Modes of Access to Mobile Phones in Mumbai, India”, **AoIR Annual Meeting | SSP Annual Meeting**.
20. 2021. “The Gender Dynamics of App-Mediated Work in Urban India”. Talk for **Socio-Legal Studies Workshop**, UC Irvine.
21. 2021. “Survey Research Methods”. Guest Lecture, **Research Methods course**, Summer Session, UC Irvine.
22. 2021. “Fighting Gender Inequality with Coding + Social Science”. Guest Lecture for **Girls Tech Camp**, National Center for Women and Information Technology, USA.
23. 2019. “Smartphones and Gender Fault Lines: How are Adolescent Girls and Young women Navigating?” **Imagine a Feminist Internet: Research, Practice and Policy in South Asia conference**. Internet Democracy Project, Sri Lanka.
24. 2018. “Why Loiter? Women Claiming Online Public Space”. **National Conference on Gender-Based Cyber Violence**, Tata Institute of Social Sciences, Mumbai, India.

CONFERENCE ORGANIZING

1. 2027. **Coordinator**. ‘Interrogating digital selves and subjectivities’ sub-theme, **Indian Association of Women’s Studies Annual Conference**.
2. 2022. **Co-Workshop Organizer**. “Context Convergence in Mobile Phone Use: Mapping Multiplicities of Presence, Digital Inequalities and Wellbeing Across the Global North and South”. **ICA Mobile Pre-Conference**.
3. 2021. **Co-Panel Organizer**, 'Transgenerational Listening: Telling Stories about Global STS Programs and Formations' Open Panel, **4S Annual Meeting**.
4. 2021. **Co-Panel Organizer**, 'Celebrating and Critiquing Feminist Inclusion Strategies in Technoscience Communities', Open Panel, **4S Annual Meeting**.

TRAINING AND WORKSHOPS

- 2024. AIIS Dissertation-to-Book Workshop, University of Wisconsin-Madison.
- 2021. Summer Institute in Computational Social Science, UCLA.
- 2021. Suicide Prevention Gatekeep Training, UCI Counselling Center.
- 2020. Summer Institute on ‘AI and Governance’, Berkman Klein Center for Internet and Society, Harvard University.
- 2020. NSF Problem-Solving Sociology Dissertation Proposal Development Workshop, Northwestern University.

SELECTED SERVICE WORK

- **Volunteer** for women-led gig worker organizations in India 2023-pres
- **Facilitator**, Labor Tech Research Network – India Collective 2025-pres
- **Reviewer**, New Media and Society; Information, Communication and Society; Journal of

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| Consumer Culture; Gender, Development and Technology | 2022-pres |
| • Co-Chair , Transnational STS Working Group, Student Section of 4S
2021-22 | |
| • Student Member , Diversity and Inclusion Committee, CITAMS, ASA | 2021 |
| • Student Member , Graduate Admissions Committee, Sociology, UC Irvine | 2021-23 |
| • Executive Editor , The Fifth Estate, IIT Madras (Student-run Campus News Body) | 2016-17 |
| o Led a team of 50 editors, writers and media personnel and managed a regular publication schedule | |
| • Founder and Member , Committee to Prepare Guidelines for Sexual Harassment Policy, Student Legislative Council, IIT Madras. | 2016-17 |

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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| • Course Instructor , ‘Platforms, Inequality & Participatory Cultures’, Stanford University | 2025 |
| • Inclusive Instruction Working Group , UC Irvine | 2019 |
| • Created teaching resources including Inclusive Teaching Practices: A Practical Guide and the Accessible Teaching Habits Checklist | |
| • Teaching Assistantships (selected) | |
| o ‘Sociology Majors Seminar’, UC Irvine | 2021 |
| o ‘People and Society’, UC Irvine. | 2018 |
| o ‘Law and Society’, UC Irvine. | 2018 |
| o ‘Introduction to Psychology’, UC Irvine | 2020 |

REFERENCES

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- Prof. Angèle Christin, Dept. of Communication, Stanford University (angelec@stanford.edu)
 - Prof. Rachel Goldberg, Dept. of Sociology, UC Irvine (rachel.goldberg@uci.edu)
 - Prof. Swethaa Ballakrishnen, School of Law, UC Irvine (sballakrishnen@law.uci.edu)
 - Prof. Francesca Polletta, Dept. of Sociology, UC Irvine (polletta@uci.edu)